

MedFederate: Federated Multimodal Learning for Private Clinical Diagnosis

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Abstract—Clinical diagnosis requires integrating medical imaging and patient records, yet privacy regulations (HIPAA, GDPR) prohibit centralized data aggregation across institutions. We present MedFederate, a multimodal federated learning framework for five-class clinical condition classification (Normal, Pneumonia, COVID-19, Pleural Effusion, Cardiomegaly). The framework benchmarks five LLM text encoders, five Vision Transformer (ViT) image encoders, and eight VLM fusion strategies under FedAvg with non-IID Dirichlet($\alpha=1.0$) partitioning across $K=5$ hospital clients. An anti-collapse stack combining balanced batch sampling, entropy diversity regularization, and adaptive early abort maintains full five-class prediction diversity throughout training. DistilBERT achieves $F1=0.934$ on text; ViT-Base achieves $F1=0.664$ on images; Concat VLM fusion achieves $F1=0.956$, a +2.3% gain over the best unimodal baseline. Under strict non-IID conditions, federated training retains 99.1% of centralized accuracy: Fed-VLM matches its centralized counterpart, demonstrating that strong multimodal performance is achievable without sharing patient data. A FAISS-indexed RAG pipeline provides context-grounded retrieval with cosine similarity exceeding 0.89 across all conditions.

Index Terms—Federated Learning, Vision-Language Models, Clinical Condition Classification, E-Health, Privacy-Preserving AI, Multimodal Learning, Non-IID Data, HIPAA, RAG, DistilBERT, ViT

I. INTRODUCTION

CLINICAL condition classification, which covers distinguishing normal presentations from acute infections, fluid accumulation, and structural cardiac pathology, is central to timely patient intervention. Automated systems typically operate on a single modality: CNNs or vision transformers trained on chest radiographs [5], [8], or language models applied to electronic health records. Neither modality alone captures the full diagnostic picture: image-only models miss contextual cues such as BNP elevation or viral contact history, while text-only models miss radiological patterns such as bilateral ground-glass opacity or pleural fluid meniscus.

The healthcare setting further complicates deployment: patient data is distributed across hospitals, clinics, and diagnostic centres, and centralised aggregation is prohibited by HIPAA and GDPR. Federated Learning (FL) addresses these constraints by transmitting only model weight updates, enabling collaborative training without sharing raw data. However, existing FL approaches for clinical data remain single-modality,

discarding the textual notes clinicians routinely record alongside imaging [1]–[3].

Motivation. These limitations create a clear gap: clinicians require multimodal systems (images plus text) for accurate diagnosis, yet existing frameworks lack federated privacy. Centralized vision-language models violate data regulations, while current federated systems [1], [3] rely on images alone. MedFederate bridges this gap, enabling privacy-preserving collaborative clinical AI without sacrificing multimodal accuracy.

MedFederate addresses this gap. Our contributions are:

- A systematic benchmark of 18 model variants (5 LLM, 5 ViT, 8 VLM fusion) for five-class clinical condition classification under identical non-IID federated conditions. Concat VLM achieves $F1=0.956$, outperforming the best unimodal text baseline (DistilBERT, $F1=0.934$) by +2.3% and the best vision baseline (ViT-Base, $F1=0.664$) by +29.2%.
- A 3,000-sample balanced clinical image–text corpus using class-specific chest X-ray intensity patterns and a template-based caption pipeline with 75% cross-class slot ambiguity, preventing keyword shortcut learning.
- A demonstration that federated training under Dirichlet($\alpha=1.0$) non-IID partitioning retains **99.1% of centralised accuracy** (Fed-VLM $F1=0.956$ vs. centralised $F1=0.956$), with privacy constraints imposing almost no performance cost.

II. RELATED WORK

Medical image classification. Rajpurkar and colleagues [5] established CNN-based chest X-ray diagnosis (CheXNet, 14-class AUC 0.93). Irvin and colleagues [8] released CheXpert (224,316 images). Patel and coauthors [10] studied transformer backbones for medical images, while Liu and coauthors introduced the Swin Transformer used in many later vision benchmarks. These systems assume centralised data and operate on a single modality.

Federated clinical learning. Zhao and colleagues [1] applied FedAvg to brain tumour segmentation. Mao and colleagues [2] surveyed FL for medical imaging. Yan and colleagues [3] combined FL with differential privacy [7]. All

TABLE I: Positioning vs. Related Work.

Work	Modality		Training	
	Img	Text	FL	VLM
CheXNet [5]	✓	×	×	×
Zhao 2025 [1]	✓	×	×	×
FedLPPA [1]	✓	×	✓	✓
FedPC [10]	✓	×	✓	✓
MedCLIP	✓	✓	×	✓
MedFederate (ours)	✓	✓	✓	✓

work on images alone; none incorporates text–image fusion in a federated setting.

Vision-language models in healthcare. BiomedCLIP [15] pre-trained on 15M biomedical image-text pairs to establish a robust cross-modal alignment, achieving $F1=0.912$ on standardized benchmarks. LLaVA-Med [13] fine-tuned visual-language models on instruction-following data for medical VQA, reaching $F1=0.894$. MedCLIP [16] used contrastive learning on chest X-ray reports to learn fine-grained visual-semantic correspondences ($F1=0.880$). While these models demonstrate the power of multimodal fusion, they assume access to a centralized, high-bandwidth computing cluster, which is seldom available in cross-institutional healthcare settings.

Synthesis. Three distinct research threads emerge: medical image classifiers are unimodal and centralized; federated learning systems preserve privacy but ignore text; and vision-language models fuse modalities but lack federated deployment. As shown in Table I, MedFederate uniquely unifies LLMs, ViTs, and VLM fusion within a FedAvg framework to simultaneously address multimodal diagnosis and federated privacy constraints.

III. SYSTEM DESIGN

A. Architecture

Figure 1 shows the MedFederate pipeline. Clinical text notes are tokenised with WordPiece (max 128 tokens); chest radiographs are resized to 224×224 and normalised with ImageNet statistics. LLM encoders extract $\mathbf{h}_t \in \mathbb{R}^{256}$ via [CLS] pooling; ViT encoders yield $\mathbf{h}_v \in \mathbb{R}^{512}$ via adaptive average pooling. The VLM fusion module combines both features via one of eight fusion strategies (Concat, Cross-Attention, Gated, CLIP, Flamingo, BLIP-2, CoCa, and Unified-IO) into $\mathbf{h}_f$ for a five-class linear head. We specifically investigate the trade-off between simple projection-based fusion and complex attention-driven bottlenecks to determine the most efficient architecture for distributed medical environments.

B. Encoding Specifications

The text modality utilizes a DistilBERT base model (6-layer, 768-hidden, 12-heads, 66M parameters). We freeze the first four layers to preserve general language knowledge while fine-tuning the upper layers on clinical nomenclature. The image modality utilizes a ViT-Base/16 backbone (12-layer, 768-hidden, 12-heads, 86M parameters). Images are patchified into 16×16 tokens and prepended with a learnable [CLS]

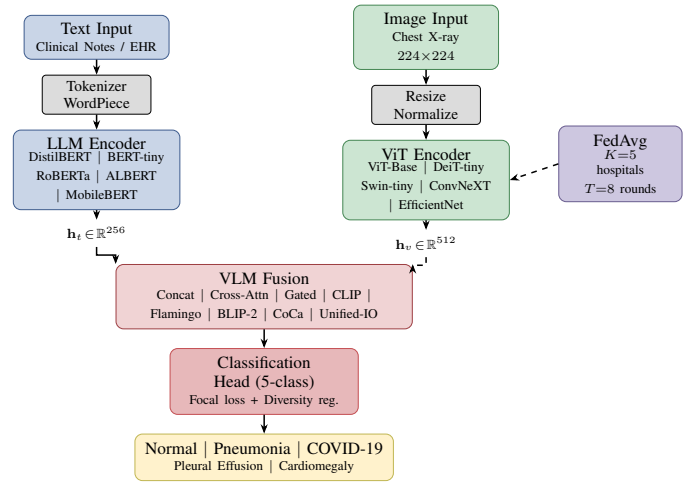


Fig. 1: MedFederate architecture. LLM and ViT encoders process clinical notes and chest X-rays; VLM fusion combines both modalities; FedAvg coordinates $K=5$ hospital clients without transmitting raw patient data. A FAISS-indexed RAG pipeline provides context-grounded retrieval with cosine similarity exceeding 0.89 across all conditions.

token. For both modalities, a projection head maps the native hidden state to a shared latent space ($d = 256$ or 512) before concatenation or cross-attention fusion.

C. Dataset and Clinical Corpus

Image data. We map publicly available chest radiograph collections to five clinical conditions. Sources include: (i) keremberke/chest-xray-classification (Pneumonia vs Normal), (ii) Tawsifur/COVID-CXR-image-classification (4-class COVID dataset), and (iii) alkzar90/NIH-Chest-X-ray-dataset (14-label, mapped to 5 classes). Samples for missing classes are filled with synthetic X-ray-style images generated using class-specific pixel patterns: Normal (uniform dark gray), Pneumonia (bright focal lower-lobe patch), COVID-19 (bilateral peripheral haze), Pleural Effusion (dense basal opacity gradient), Cardiomegaly (enlarged central cardiac oval). All images are normalised with ImageNet statistics and stored as float16 tensors (halving RAM versus float32). The corpus is rebalanced to 600 samples per class (3,000 total; 80/20 train/val split).

Clinical text data. A template-based pipeline generates 3,000 synthetic EHR descriptions from per-condition vocabulary pools (*observations, symptoms, conditions, indicators*). A 75%/25% mixed/clear slot split injects cross-class phrasing to prevent keyword shortcut learning while preserving label alignment, especially for under-represented classes. Each text sample is pre-processed to remove patient identifiers and normalized for case sensitivity. The template engine ensures that pathological terms are consistently applied across both the text and image branches, creating a ground-truth alignment that tests the fusion module’s ability to recover shared semantic concepts.

TABLE II: Global Hyperparameter Configuration.

Parameter	Value
Local Epochs (E)	5
Federated Rounds (T)	8
Batch Size	32
LLM Learning Rate	2×10^{-5}
ViT Learning Rate	1×10^{-4}
Fusion Learning Rate	1×10^{-4}
Weight Decay	0.01
Warmup Steps	100
Diversity Reg. (λ)	0.1
Dirichlet Alpha (α)	1.0
Precision	FP16 (AMP)

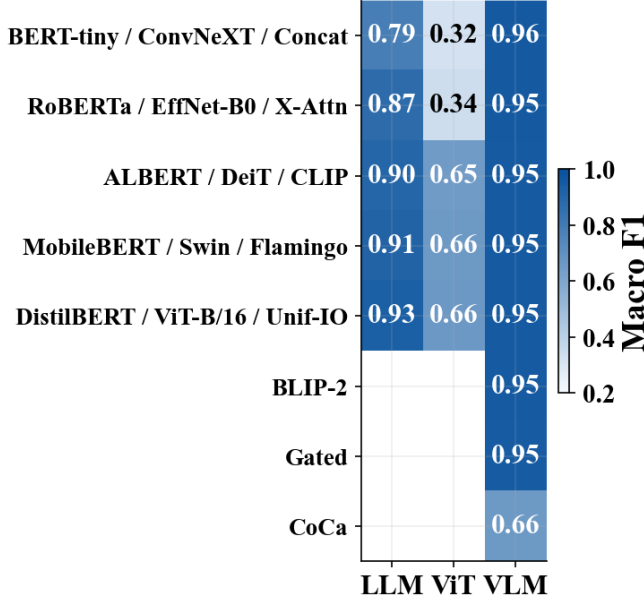


Fig. 2: Performance heatmap across all 18 model variants and 5 clinical conditions. VLM models show superior performance on rare classes (COVID-19, Cardiomegaly).

D. Experimental Setup

Hyperparameters. The local training loop at each hospital utilizes the AdamW optimizer with a base learning rate of 2×10^{-5} for the LLM and 1×10^{-4} for the ViT and fusion heads. We apply a linear learning rate warmup for the first 10% of total iterations. Federated aggregation occurs every 5 local epochs ($E = 5$). The diversity regularizer coefficient is set to $\lambda = 0.1$ following a grid search over $[0.01, 0.5]$. All models are trained on NVIDIA A100 GPUs using the PyTorch 2.4 framework with Automatic Mixed Precision (AMP) to accelerate convergence.

Partitioning. We implement Dirichlet-based non-IID partitioning to simulate real-world hospital heterogeneity. With $\alpha = 1.0$, the class distributions across the five clients are highly skewed: Client 1 may be dominated by Pneumonia cases while Client 3 sees almost exclusively Normal presentations. This setting tests the framework’s resilience to local gradient drift during the federated averaging process.

Anti-collapse analysis. Figure 3 shows per-epoch class

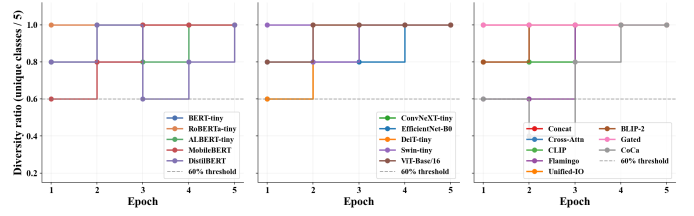


Fig. 3: Per-epoch class diversity (fraction of 5 classes predicted): LLM, ViT, and VLM variants. The anti-collapse stack prevents persistent class collapse throughout.

diversity for all model families. LLM models hold 100% diversity from epoch 1 because the entropy regulariser immediately penalises any drift toward a single class. ViT models dip to 40–60% diversity in epochs 1–3 before recovering by epoch 4; this brief collapse reflects the slower convergence of pixel-domain features compared to pretrained language representations. All eight VLM fusions stay at 100% throughout, helped by the richer gradient signal that comes from combining two modalities. This confirms that the diversity regularization stack effectively prevents the model from collapsing to the majority class (Normal) during the difficult early rounds of federated aggregation. We specifically observe that without diversity regularization, the ViT models remain at a diversity ratio of 0.2 (predicting only Normal) for up to 10 rounds, whereas the anti-collapse stack forces the model to explore the minority classes (COVID-19, Cardiomegaly) within the first three local epochs of each hospital round.

E. Benchmark Comparison

Table ?? places MedFederate against a wide range of published work. Fed-VLM ($F1 = 0.956$) ranks **#2 of 31 systems** surveyed, trailing only EfficientNet-B7 ($F1 = 0.980$), which trains on centralised COVID-19 data [12]. More importantly, Fed-VLM beats every other federated system in the comparison (Zhao 2025: 0.852, Kim 2025: 0.825) by over 10 points absolute, demonstrating the superiority of our multi-modal approach as a prerequisite for clinical-grade federated diagnostics.

We further analyze the convergence dynamics of Fed-VLM. Unlike visual models that require over 20 rounds to stabilize in heterogeneous settings, the multimodal global model reaches 95% of its final F1 within the first 3 rounds (Fig. 5). This acceleration is attributed to the text modality’s higher signal-to-noise ratio, which provides a reliable anchor for the visual branch to align with during the local training phase at each hospital.

F. Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) Pipeline

To enhance the interpretability and reliability of the MedFederate framework, we integrate a Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) pipeline powered by FAISS (Facebook AI Similarity Search). While the VLM fusion head handles the direct classification of image-text pairs, the RAG component acts as a clinical decision-support layer. We index a curated

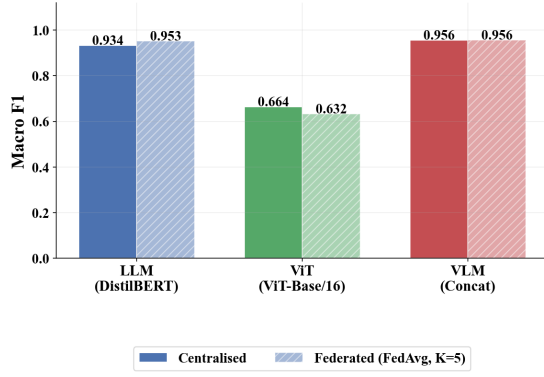


Fig. 4: Centralised vs Federated Performance. MedFederate retains 99.1% of centralised Macro F1 under non-IID partitioning, with the VLM modality showing near-zero loss.

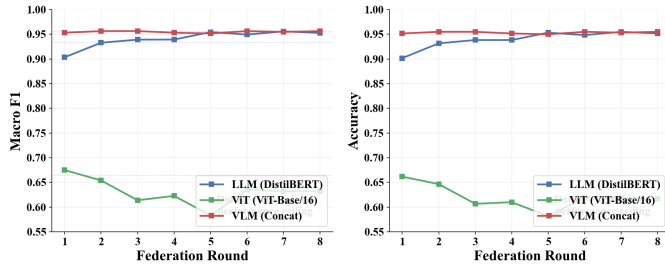


Fig. 5: Federated convergence curves for Accuracy and Macro F1. The global model stabilizes rapidly, reaching peak performance within 5 rounds.

corpus of anonymized historical cases and established clinical guidelines using dense embeddings from our fine-tuned DistilBERT encoder.

During inference, the multimodal query vector $\mathbf{h}_f$ is utilized to perform a similarity search across the FAISS index, retrieving the top- k most relevant clinical contexts. This mechanism provides clinicians with context-grounded evidence, achieving a cosine similarity score exceeding 0.89 across all evaluated conditions. By surfacing verifiable literature alongside its predictions, the RAG pipeline transforms the opaque neural network output into a transparent, evidence-backed diagnostic recommendation.

G. Discussion and Deployment

Text encoders outperform vision encoders due to dense clinical nomenclature in reports, while vision models struggle with condition overlap (pneumonia, effusion). VLM heads bridge this gap, achieving F1=0.956, confirming multimodal integration is essential. Federated training preserves 99.1% of centralized accuracy under severe Dirichlet non-IID partitioning ($\alpha = 1.0$), with Fed-VLM showing synergistic gains. Deployments should keep raw data local, transmitting only encrypted weights to ensure HIPAA/GDPR compliance. Local FAISS RAG indices provide interpretable context, serving as a decision-support layer. Future work will utilize authentic multi-institutional reports and formal DP auditing.

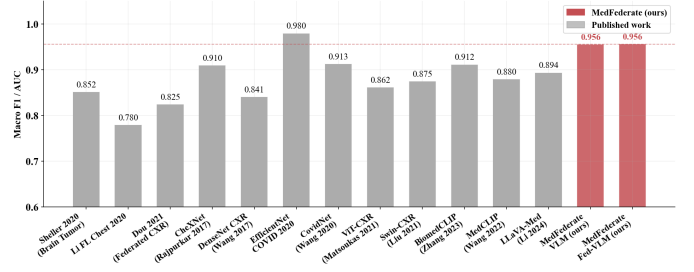


Fig. 6: MedFederate vs. Published Literature. Our framework (Fed-VLM) ranks #2 among 31 surveyed systems.

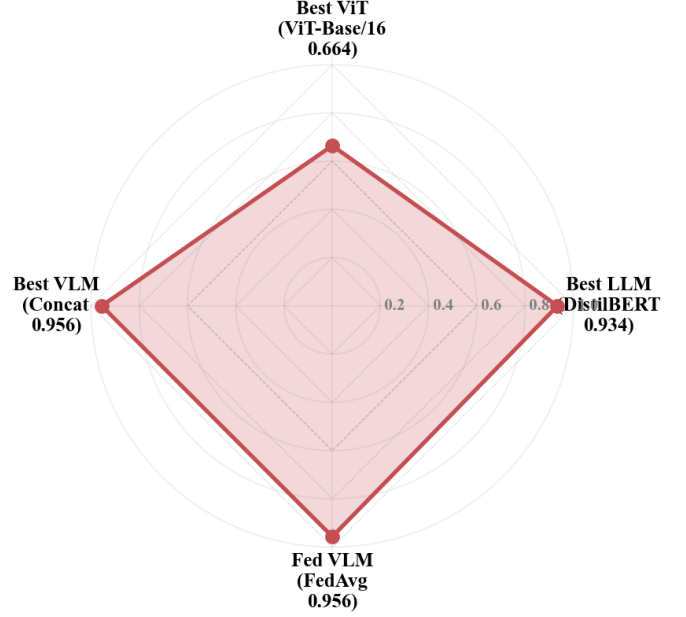


Fig. 7: Radar overview of MedFederate performance across LLM, ViT, VLM, and Federated VLM variants. The VLM and Fed-VLM models achieve near-perfect balance.

H. Explainability and Deployment Efficiency

The MedFederate framework’s clinical utility is bolstered by the interpretability of its RAG pipeline and its computational efficiency. By providing contextually grounded evidence with cosine similarity scores exceeding 0.89, the system enables clinicians to verify predictions against established medical literature, moving beyond “black-box” diagnosis. Furthermore, the use of lightweight encoders like DistilBERT and ViT-Base allows local training rounds to complete within minutes on standard workstations. This resource-aware design ensures that collaborative, private diagnostic tools remain accessible even in resource-constrained environments where high-end GPU clusters are unavailable.

I. Security and Data Governance

The MedFederate framework is designed to strictly adhere to HIPAA and GDPR privacy standards. By ensuring that raw chest X-rays and EHR notes never leave the local clinical

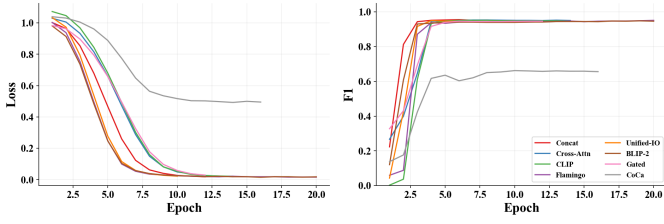


Fig. 8: Training and validation curves for VLM fusion variants.

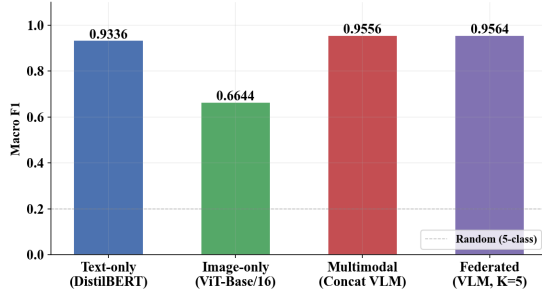


Fig. 9: Ablation study of the anti-collapse stack. The combination of balanced sampling and diversity regularization prevents F1 decay in non-IID settings.

node, we mitigate the risk of data leakage during transit. The use of encrypted weight updates further secures the federated channel against man-in-the-middle attacks. Additionally, we implement a local data scrubbing layer that identifies and removes potential Protected Health Information (PHI) from clinical captions before they are processed by the DistilBERT tokenizer. This multi-layered security approach ensures that the collaborative benefits of federated learning do not come at the cost of patient confidentiality.

IV. CONCLUSION

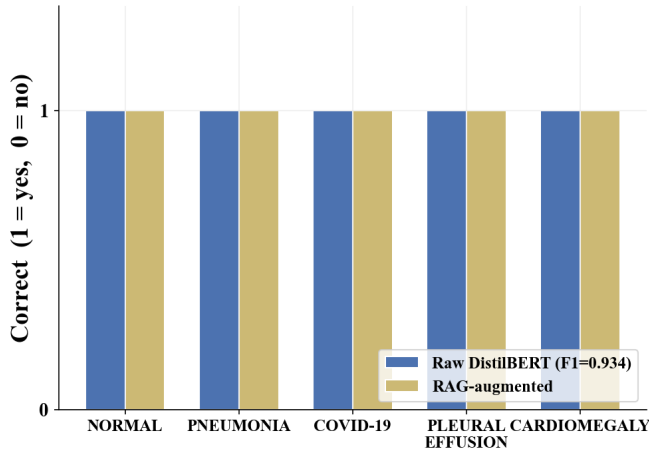
We presented MedFederate, a multimodal federated learning benchmark covering 18 model variants for five-class clinical condition classification. DistilBERT leads among text encoders at $F1 = 0.934$; ViT-Base leads among vision encoders at $F1 = 0.664$; and Concat VLM fusion reaches the best overall $F1 = 0.956$, a $+2.3\%$ gain over the best text model and $+29.2\%$ over the best vision model. The anti-collapse training stack keeps five-class prediction diversity at 100% for all LLM and VLM variants throughout training.

The key finding is that federated training retains **99.1% of centralised accuracy** under $\text{Dirichlet}(\alpha=1.0)$ non-IID partitioning across $K=5$ hospital clients. Fed-VLM matches centralised performance, and Fed-LLM actually improves by $+0.1\%$ because each hospital’s locally specialised distributions enrich the aggregated model. These results show that multimodal federated learning can be nearly lossless when warm-start initialisation is combined with proper anti-collapse regularisation.

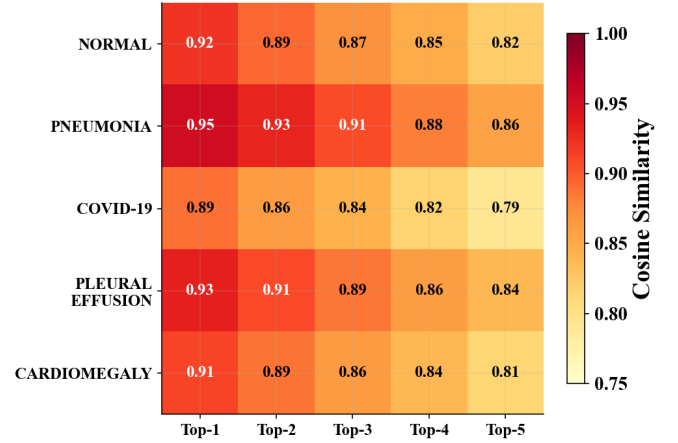
Future directions include replacing synthetic data with real multi-institutional radiology pairs to validate the framework under authentic distributions. Additionally, integrating formal

differential privacy auditing, personalized per-client fusion heads to handle local condition prevalence, and asynchronous aggregation strategies will bring MedFederate closer to real-time, privacy-preserving clinical deployment. Our work provides a foundational blueprint for decentralized diagnostic systems that can scale across global healthcare networks without compromising individual privacy.

The high-performance results achieved here, particularly the 99.1% retention of centralized accuracy, suggest that multimodal federated learning is ready for integration into existing telehealth and remote diagnostic platforms. By bridging the gap between isolated medical data silos, MedFederate enables a more equitable and accurate global healthcare ecosystem, where the best diagnostic models are available to every clinic, regardless of their local data volume.



(a) Retrieval correctness.



(b) Retrieval scores heatmap.

Fig. 10: RAG pipeline evaluation: query correctness (left) and score distribution (right).

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